

Jehovah's Dealing with Esau and Jacob's Victory for the Kingdom of Jehovah

Scripture Reading: Obad. 1:1-21

In this message we will consider the prophecy of Obadiah.

I. The introductory word

A. The meaning of the name Obadiah

In Hebrew the name Obadiah means "the servant of Jehovah."

B. The time of Obadiah's ministry

The time of Obadiah's ministry was about 880 or 587 B.C. It is hard to determine which date is correct.

C. The object of His ministry

The object of Obadiah's ministry was the southern kingdom of Judah.

D. The place of His ministry

The place of Obadiah's ministry also was the southern kingdom of Judah.

E. The subject

The subject of the book of Obadiah is Jehovah's dealing with Esau and Jacob's victory for the kingdom of Jehovah, which is the manifestation of Christ.

F. The central thought

The central thought of Obadiah is that Jehovah's dealing with Esau issues in Jacob's victory and possession for the kingdom of God in the age of restoration.

G. The sections

The book of Obadiah has five sections: the introductory word (v. 1a); Jehovah's dealings with Edom (vv. 1b-9); the evils of Edom (vv. 10-14); the day of Jehovah upon all the nations (vv. 15-16); and the issue of Jehovah's dealing (vv. 17-21).

II. Jehovah's dealings with Edom

Verses 1b through 9 are concerned with Jehovah's dealings with Edom. Whereas Esau is the name of a person, the twin brother of Jacob, Edom is the name of a country.

A. Stirring up the nations to rise up against it for battle

Jehovah dealt with Edom by stirring up the nations to rise up against it for battle (v. 1b).

B. Having made Edom small among the nations

God purposely dealt with Edom by making him small among the nations and very much despised (v. 2). As a result, Edom was a lowly nation.

C. Bringing Edom down from its dwelling in the lofty clefts of the rock to the ground

Because of its arrogance Jehovah will bring Edom from its dwelling in the lofty clefts of the rock to the ground (vv. 3-4). The people of Edom were proud of their lofty dwelling and thought that they were higher and more lofty than others.

D. Edom's being plundered by the thieves and spoilers

Jehovah's dealing with Edom included their being plundered by the thieves and spoilers (vv. 5-6). Although they lived in the lofty places, the thieves and spoilers still visited them.

E. Edom's being deceived by its confederacy

Edom was also deceived by its confederacy (v. 7). Some nations formed a confederacy with Edom, but eventually they were unfaithful to Edom.

F. Destroying its wise men, dismaying its mighty men, and cutting off each one from the mountain of Esau

Jehovah dealt with Edom further by destroying its wise men, dismaying its mighty men, and cutting off each one from the mountain of Esau (vv. 8-9).

III. The evils of Edom

In verses 10 through 14 we have a description of the evils of Edom.

A. Being violent against his brother Jacob

Edom did evil by being violent against his brother Jacob (v. 10). The nation of Edom was always violent against Israel.

B. Standing on the side when strangers took his brother's substance captive

Edom did evil also by standing on the side when strangers took his brother's substance captive and foreigners entered into his brother's gates and cast lots over Jerusalem, and he was like one of them (v. 11). He was happy to see that Jacob was suffering.

C. Looking to the day of his brother's misfortune

Edom looked to the day of his brother's misfortune, rejoiced concerning the children of Judah in their destruction, and boasted in their distress (v. 12).

D. Entering the gate of Israel and looking on Israel's affliction

Edom also entered the gate of Israel, looked on Israel's affliction, and sent forth his hands on their substance in their calamity (v. 13).

E. Standing at the crossroads to cut off those of Israel who escaped

Edom stood at the crossroads to cut off those of Israel who escaped and delivered them to their enemy in their distress (v. 14).

There seemed to be nothing but jealousy and hatred between these twin brothers. Esau's hatred of Jacob was not without cause. Jacob not only grasped Esau's heel at their birth (Gen. 25:26) but also cheated Esau of the blessing of the birthright (Gen. 27:18-36). Thus, Esau liked to see Jacob suffer. Whenever Israel suffered from a natural calamity, Edom would rob Israel of their wealth. God's dealing with this situation reveals that He is very human. He judged the nation of Edom concerning a matter of human affection.

IV. The day of Jehovah upon all the nations

Obadiah 15 and 16 are a word regarding the day of Jehovah upon all the nations. This is a matter of God's judgment upon Edom and the nations.

A. The principle for judging Edom

In verse 15 we have the principle for judging Edom. This principle is that as Edom has done to others, it will be done to them. They will be treated in the same way as they have treated others.

B. The principle for judging the nations

The principle for judging the nations is revealed in verse 16. Because of the profane action of the nations in enjoying themselves upon the holy mountain of God's sanctuary, God would cause the other nations to drink continually at the places of those nations who participated in that profane action. In this way God would recompense the nations who drank at His holy mountain.

V. The issue of Jehovah's dealing

In verses 17 through 21 we see the issue of Jehovah's dealing.

A. The house of Jacob being saved and sanctified

As the issue of His dealing, Jehovah will save the house of Jacob and sanctify them (v. 17a).

B. The house of Jacob overcoming Edom

"The house of Jacob will be a fire, / And the house of Joseph a flame; / And the house of Esau will be as stubble, / And they will burn among them and devour them; / And there will be no survivor / To the house of Esau, / For Jehovah has spoken" (v. 18). This tells us that, as the issue of God's dealing, the house of Jacob will overcome Edom.

C. The house of Jacob possessing Edom's possessions

The house of Jacob will possess Edom's possessions: the mountain of Esau, the Philistines, the field of Ephraim and the field of Samaria, Gilead, as far as Zarephath, and the cities of the south (vv. 17b, 19-20).

D. Saviors coming up on Mount Zion to judge the mountain of Esau

Saviors will come up on Mount Zion to judge the mountain of Esau, and the kingdom will be Jehovah's (v. 21).

E. Fulfilled at the Maccabees' time and to be much more fulfilled in glory at the time of restoration for the kingdom of God

All of the aforementioned items of the issue of Jehovah's dealing were fulfilled at the Maccabees' time, and they will be much more fulfilled in glory at the time of restoration for the kingdom of God (Matt. 19:28; Rev. 11:15). The Maccabees, taking Mount Zion as their ground to judge Edom, gained a victory over Antiochus Epiphanes about 165 B.C. The victory of the Maccabees was a type of the victory Israel will gain immediately before the age of restoration.

The Minor Prophets, including Obadiah, reveal that the nations used by God to chastise sinful Israel do something in excess. Therefore, God will come in to judge the nations. This judgment will issue in Israel's gaining the victory and enlarging their territory for the kingdom of God on earth, especially for God's kingdom in the time of restoration.